Food For Thought

An Anthology of Insight and Awareness

By

Gail Pursell Elliott

"All people want and have the right
To be treated with Dignity and Respect. No Exceptions."

If you like that statement, you'll like this book.

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1

The Power Of Communication

People are naturally self-centered, that's just the way we are made. We are trapped within these biological units we call bodies. It gets pretty lonely in here, so we reach out to connect with others. That attempt at connecting is called communication, in all of it's forms. But because we're self-centered, we translate everything that comes in through our senses in terms of how it relates to us, to our experience. So we wind up taking everything personally. Everyone does this. So all of our words and actions have to do with us and all of our perceptions have to do with us. When we communicate with someone we are doing that in terms of ourselves, but the other person perceives our communication to be in terms of themselves, because they are self centered too. It's a wonder we can coexist or connect at all! How do we do this?

First we begin by recognizing that although we're self-centered, we're also thinking beings. We can consciously get outside of that mental box and recognize the tremendous personal power that we have to make another person's day joyous or miserable.



The interactions we have
with anyone will affect
at least the next five people
that person encounters.
This is **POWER.**

II

LIFE CHANGING EXPERIENCES

(THE LEGACY)

We touch the lives of others in ways we often never know. People sometimes come into our personal world for fleeting moments and can leave us forever changed. We have more power to create or to destroy than we can imagine. We can leave things or individuals better or worse than we found them. A look, a word, a gesture has tremendous impact and frequently we blither along through our existence unaware of the mighty power that our communication wields.

Here's an example: It was a rainy, humid day: the mother of all bad hair days. I wasriding on a bus downtown to go to work. The windows on the bus were covered in condensation so thick you couldn't see outside. Everyone was wilting. I was sitting next to a man in a business suit and didn't pay much attention until we both got off at the same stop and walked to the same newsstand to get a morning paper.

The man running the stand was obviously having a bad day. He was rude, abrupt and unsmiling as we purchased our papers, which served to only add more gloom to my day. The businessman caught my eye and smiled. He then proceeded to smile brightly,

thank the newsstand proprietor for the paper and for being open on such a morning to make sure we were able to get our papers. In short, he expressed his appreciation for something most of us would take for granted. The man running the newsstand responded only with a grunt and a sour expression. The businessman then pleasantly wished him a pleasant day. As we turned away, I asked this man why he had continued to be pleasant to the newsman when he obviously didn't care about and didn't respond to his expression of appreciation and friendliness.

The businessman grinned at me and said, "Why would I let someone else control what I say and what I feel or what kind of day I'm going to have?"

We then separated to go to our respective work places. To this day, I don't know who that business man was, where he worked, or anything else about him. I never saw him again, even though I looked for him on the bus on other days. He appeared briefly in my life and disappeared just as quickly. I don't even remember what he looked like. But I've never forgotten the words he said or the way his smile seemed like a shaft of light on a gloomy day.

That was a good 25 years ago, but the impact this had on my life has lasted. I never had a chance to thank him personally, but the way in which I try to choose to look at life as a result of those words is his legacy to me and my thanks to him. Our interactions with the people we encounter can impact at least the next five people that person encounters. A smile and words of simple appreciation multiply themselves geometrically.

We cannot control people and situations that come to us, but we can always control our response to them.
In such positive decisions lie our control and personal power to make a positive difference.
It's something anyone and everyone can do. It is a real legacy that can impact both the present and the future.

"Why would I let someone else control what I say and what I feel or what kind of day I'm going to have?"

III

Are You Treating People Like Pets?

Years ago a friend of mine had a job in a 24 hour donut shop. He worked the night shift alone making dozens of donuts of all varieties. Since he was the only one on duty, he also had to wait on customers who came in during the night. His regular complaint was "these customers keep coming in and keep me from getting my work done." What was he doing? Making donuts. Who was he making them for? Customers. He wanted them to come in when it was convenient for him, not when they wanted or needed to be served. He was treating people like pets and didn't realize it.

Many people who have pets really love them. They are like members of the family. We feed our pets, take them out, make sure they have attention, train them well, give affection, play with them, take them to the vet for their checkups and so forth. Some of us even talk to our pets.

But when another human being is in the room do we include our pet in the conversation? If our pet tries to participate does it become a pest? Do we talk about our pets in front of them to others? When our pet wants attention and we're busy doing something else, even if it's getting the pet's food ready, do we stop to acknowledge the pet and communicate? When responsibilities come up, do we explain to our pet that we

won't be around or why we're leaving? Do we tell our pet what it can expect from us

People are people and pets are pets. Honoring people as individuals with the right to dignity and respect precludes treating people like pets, objects or opportunities. The phraseology that refers to people having wants, hopes, needs, dreams, and desires that need to be addressed, is well taken and applies to us all, not just to a specific group of people, but to all people. Applying this phrase to a specific group still promotes the view of separateness rather than inclusion. To really achieve what we wish to achieve requires us to apply this philosophy with everyone we encounter, whether the person at the convenience store, at home, our coworkers, or others both in and out of our personal sphere. It must be pervasive to be effective.

"We must live the philosophy
To achieve the dream."

IV

Acknowledgment

Try calling a place of business. Press one for this, press two for that, press three for this, press four for that. Most people say they feel really frustrated by this type of communication. Even though we may get the information we need, there is some sense of being 'let down' that accompanies it.

Every person has the basic need for acknowledgment. We want to be acknowledged as a human being by another human being. Just acknowledged. A computer or a recording can't take the place of that, no matter how 'interactive' it is.

Eventually we might get to talk to a 'real person' but by then, we may feel pretty annoyed. We may wind up 'sharing' those negative feelings with the next person with whom we interact. We're driven even further into our bubble of self-centeredness because we've taken the situation personally, and it becomes harder to acknowledge others and treat them with dignity and respect.

Yet, this is precisely the type of circumstance in which we can 'make a difference' by remembering to acknowledge the person that we finally reach or the next person with whom we interact.

Here are a few of the definitions of the word ‘acknowledge’ - “to admit to be real or true, recognize the existence of, express appreciation or gratitude for.” All this requires is thoughtful response to the person rather than reaction to our own feelings.

When we ‘make the difference’ for another person through acknowledgment, we also make the difference for ourselves. We may think this will come from a positive response from the other person, and part of it may be that. More important, however, is the adjustment we make in our own attitude and focus to accomplish it. Acknowledgment is a positive power that quickly can restore our own sense of balance and control. It’s a great way to treat others and ourselves with dignity and respect.

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V

THE MAGIC THAT IS YOU

We all have idiosyncrasies. Some people call them 'personal warts.' I like to call them the 'magic' that makes us the unique individuals that we are. Some of these in others may be irritating to us, especially if they are very different from our own. When we accept them as part of the 'magic' that makes that person unique and special, we may find that some of those irritating ways are essential to the expression of that person – and may even contribute to other qualities that we find more appealing.

I've found that people who truly accept and appreciate themselves positively, just as they are, generally extend that to others. They don't compare and they don't judge – that kind of thinking stems from a certain level of internal non-acceptance. Feelings of superiority usually launch themselves from the opposite feeling – in an attempt to achieve some balance.

People often make 'resolutions' to change what they feel are personal negatives without realizing that they are engaging in self put-downs. Treating people with dignity and respect of course has to begin with treating ourselves that way. Without that, we have no points of reference from which to begin. Things that 'bug' us about others usually do so because we take them personally. Realizing that they are just part of the

'magic' that is that person, takes the focus away from us. And if we want to treat others with dignity and respect – that is just where the focus should be.

... people who truly accept
and appreciate themselves positively,
generally extend that to others.

How we treat others is a direct reflection
Of how we feel about ourselves.

VI

Crossing The Bridge To Forgiveness

When we are deeply hurt by another person's actions, it may take months or years for us to be able to cross the bridge to forgiveness. On the side where we begin are our feelings of hurt, pain, anger, frustration, or humiliation that we must leave behind us. We begin in the past. On the other side of the bridge is the future. The bridge is like a narrow footbridge swaying in the wind. We can't take anything of the past with us if we intend to arrive safely on the other side. No excess baggage can come along. The bridge can only sustain our own weight. And we need both hands to hold onto its flimsy rope railings.

I wrote about this bridge years ago in one of my poems. Here is part of it:

"The narrow footbridge sways in wind

Only myself to confuse my steps

Nothing distracts from the opposite shore

And yet the bridge slats separate

Cause feet to jump like a chess knight

One over two forward

Two over one back

And the groaning shivers the rope

That slides in my grip – a hairy thing."

So how do we accomplish this? Here is a technique that I developed a number of years ago during one of the many difficult times that we all experience in our lives. I saw myself driving my car up the interstate in a severe snowstorm. I was warm and safe in a reliable vehicle. There was no other traffic on this highway but me. Up ahead there was a vehicle on the side of the road. Stranded. The driver inside was the person who had hurt me.

The first time I saw this image in my mind, I laughed, made an obscene gesture at this person, thought – you deserve this, and kept on driving. I wanted revenge but not the responsibility for perpetrating it. That told me I had not begun to cross the bridge. As time went on, I kept bringing the image back to mind and I noticed as my ability to forgive and move on developed, my behavior toward the stranded motorist changed. At another point I just drove by and ignored him. Later I drove by but got off the highway and reported that the person was stranded. Initially it was many miles and exits before I could do this. Later it became the next exit.

Did I finally get to the point at which I stopped to help? Yes. Had I crossed the bridge? Not quite. My behavior toward this person went through a metamorphosis with each imagining. The things I said and did, the interactions became more impersonal over time until I finally was able to see this other person as simply a fellow human being in need of assistance that I was able to give without expecting anything in return. When I reached that point, my journey across the bridge was finished and my own healing was complete. I was able to move on.

This technique worked for me. Did it take a long time? Yes. Have I had to use it more than once? Yes. Does it get easier each time? No. Is it worth it? Yes!

When we withhold forgiveness we are keeping ourselves caught in a negative pattern of self-abuse without even knowing it. We perpetuate our pain and persecute ourselves when we keep unforgiving thoughts and feelings alive. We can even make ourselves physically ill as a result of this.

Often in our lives we think we have moved on from experiences, but we are unable to cross the bridge to forgiveness. Why is this important? Because of what is waiting for us on the other side: our life, waiting to be lived fully and not halfway or encumbered.

You may wish to imagine some other scenario. Something else may work better for you in gauging where you are on the bridge to forgiveness. But do cross it. No matter how long it takes. It is one of the greatest gifts you can give yourself.

Forgiveness isn't something we do for the person we are forgiving.
It is a gift that we give ourselves.

VII

A Hard Lesson In Dignity And Respect

One beautiful summer evening when I was eight years old, I sat cross-legged on the floor watching TV. Too close as usual. My grandmother was sitting way at the back of the room in an easy chair, watching with me and doing the mending. My mom hated to sew, and would save it all up in a laundry basket. Whenever my grandfather was out of town on business for more than a day or two, my grandmother would come and stay with us and the mending would get done. Always while sitting in that chair and watching TV.

My grandmother wasn't well educated. I don't know if she even finished high school. Probably not. Back in her day a high school diploma was a major accomplishment. She was an immigrant who, at age 3, entered the U. S. at Ellis Island with her mother, who herself was only 18. My grandmother was 40 years old when I was born, and at the time this story takes place, younger than I am now.

The police had been looking for someone who'd committed a pretty horrible murder. Certainly more of a rarity then than it is now, to be broadcast in the way it was. They didn't give as many details back then as they do now, don't work on the emotions

as much as the current media does, but they told enough to horrify me. There was a news bulletin that interrupted the programming. The murderer had been caught. And once again, there was an overview of the details of the crime.

I was incensed, outraged, furious at this man I didn't know. I felt hatred and the desire for vengeance welling up inside of me. And I expressed it verbally, with all the emotion that I felt inside, nothing held back. I said that I hoped that the authorities would pay kind for kind .. that this criminal would be tortured the way he had tortured his victim. Strung up from the rafters as I thought he deserved. I'm almost ashamed to admit that, but I was a kid and as human as any of us.

My grandmother absolutely exploded .. she rose from her chair and raised her voice to me, which she rarely did. "Stop it!!! Don't ever say that!!! That's someone's baby, someone's little boy, someone's child."

She didn't mean that the criminal shouldn't be dealt with or let off. She was also sickened by the act. She was addressing my attitude. One that many people emulate. This was an early lesson in "Dignity and respect. No exceptions. " Not easily achieved. I knew she was right. I had held my baby brother in my arms. I had seen the open, trusting, hopeful spirit reaching out to be loved. Trying to imagine this perpetrator in that way was really difficult for me to do. I didn't want to. It was easier just to be angry and think of him in terms of what he had done. Yet I knew in my heart that she spoke the truth, it had been so at one time .. long ago. It was humbling.

There's an old saying that 'you can't fight fire with fire.' You also can't fight evil with evil .. or legislate insight and awareness. These last have to come from within. Separating people from their actions is one of the many steps on that winding road.

All People Want
And Have The Right
To Be Treated With
Dignity and Respect
No Exceptions

Most people agree with the Dignity and Respect statement.
It's the "No Exceptions" part that's the challenge.

VIII

Always A Winner

To paraphrase Wayne Dyer, PhD, Maslow's "self-actualized person" can be defined as follows: independent of the good opinion of others; not invested in the control of others; involved in process rather than outcome. At the top of the pyramid graphic is a 'winner.'

A recent commercial portrays the winner of an event graciously congratulating his competitor on a good effort and thanking him. Then we get to hear what the person is really thinking: "Ha, ha. I'm better than you are."

There will always be people and situations in our lives that will take a greater or lesser position to ourselves and our own situations. And of course, being human, we're all naturally self-centered, take things personally, and react unless we think it through.

Winning or losing means we're competing with someone else. When we compete with others we set ourselves up. It may be too hard, and we'll lose. But even worse, it may be too easy, and we'll still lose. When we compete with ourselves we always win. We grow. We push ahead. We achieve and accomplish. We become caught up in process instead of outcome. Our focus turns to what we're doing rather

than what someone else is doing. What we think becomes more important to us than what others think.

When we compete and compare ourselves with others, we look for negatives, get involved in power struggles, and pay more attention to shortcomings and failure than potential and growth. So even if we 'win' temporarily, in the long run we lose by focusing on negatives rather than positives.

This doesn't mean that we shouldn't have goals or dream of achieving great things. But true success is based upon something other than dominating and diminishing another person. It means appreciation rather than comparison. Acknowledging others and ourselves as the unique individuals that we are. Taking another step toward the essence of dignity and respect.



IX

Appreciation Vs. Understanding

Would you rather be appreciated or understood? Think about it. Most respondents say they'd rather be appreciated. Appreciation has everything to do with being treated with dignity and respect as an individual. When we're appreciated we're accepted for who we are, just as we are.

We can't hope to completely understand each other. We tend to lead with our conclusions while operating from a basis of our own experience. Giving each other the benefit of the doubt, looking for something to appreciate in another person and then expressing that appreciation honestly and immediately goes a long way toward establishing and maintaining trust by honoring the individual. Recently I remarked to a man that his wife was a smart woman. He agreed and said, “I probably should tell her that.” “I replied, "Do it! Now!"

Too often we notice positive qualities and we think positive thoughts about others but don't express them. If you think it and it's positive, say it! You may not have another chance to capture that moment.

X

Who IS That?

When my dad's mother turned 78, I asked her what it felt like to be that old. She replied, "Well, inside I feel pretty much just like I did when I was 18. Then I look in the mirror and wonder 'Who IS that??'"

A few short years later my grandmother passed on. At her funeral, one man she'd known for years approached me in tears saying, "Your grandmother was the best friend I ever had."

Up until then, I'd never thought of my grandmother as someone's best friend. She represented many positive things to me, but her life outside of what I knew was never something I thought much about or considered. Although I grew up with her in my life, there was so much that I never saw.

I asked this man to tell me about their friendship. Through his eyes I rediscovered her. He reminisced. We laughed and cried. And he gave me a gift of insight and deeper awareness of how much of her I had missed. I thought then of a few lines from a poem that I had written for my own mother.

"She is a profoundly complex being,

not too sensational

except for those who know her."

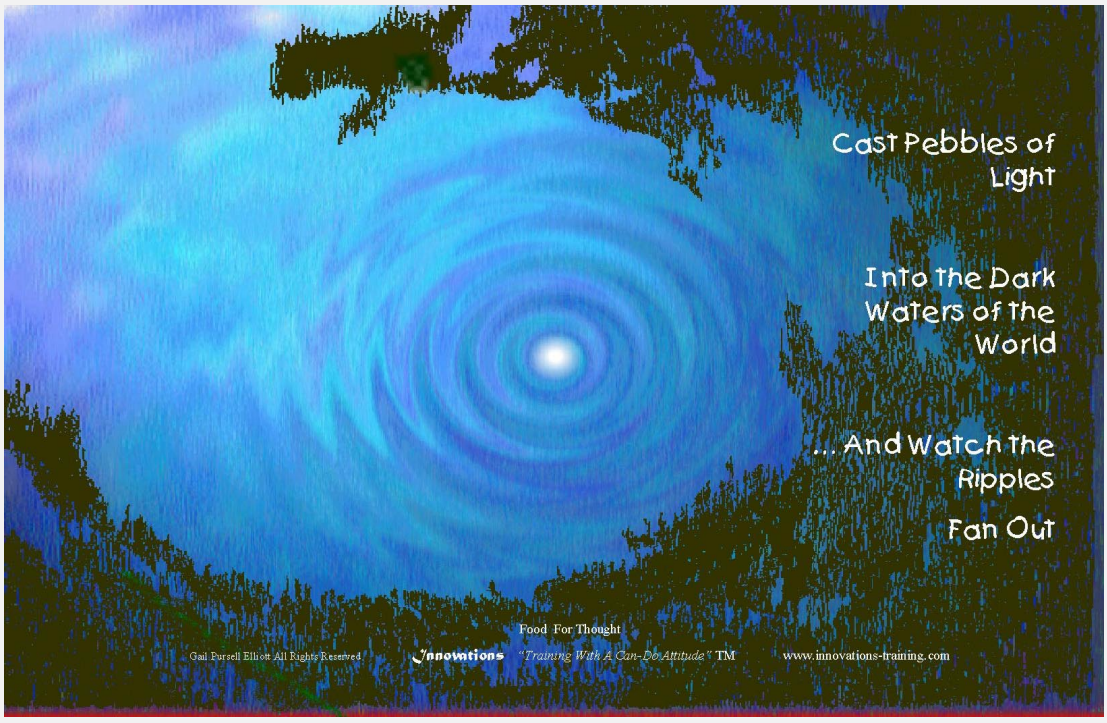
How often do we miss the serendipitous beauty of the many facets of the people who populate our world? If we only look, we'll surely find more than we could ever imagine. Not only in others, but in ourselves as well.

How often do we miss the serendipitous beauty
of the many facets of the people
who populate our world?
If we only look, we'll surely find
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Not only in others,
but in ourselves as well.

XI

Pebbles Of Light

Our words, our thoughts, and our actions are like pebbles tossed into the waters of the world. The ripples fan out in all directions. Whether we toss pebbles of light or pebbles of darkness is a true choice each of us makes, despite our awareness. The ripples fan out regardless. And they impact the whole. Everyone makes a difference, an impact on the lives of others. What that difference will be is up to us.



XII

Lasting Gifts

The most important gifts are not those that you can hold in your hand. These, in their purest form, are simply an outward representation of the gifts that are the most lasting: the gifts of time, attention, thought, caring, peace of mind, true friendship, acceptance, patience, tolerance, laughter, joy, freedom of expression, companionship, insight, understanding, compassion.

Sometimes what is really important in life becomes obscured by outer concerns. These have a tendency to make us feel poor and wanting when we are not and to pull our attention to focus on the attainment of symbols of a rich existence, which can ultimately leave us destitute if we lack perspective and balance.

Money and possessions are not in themselves important. Only what they represent has meaning. Note also that power, recognition, reputation, influence, control, and manipulation are not included on the list of lasting gifts. Our real life exists elsewhere, for if those inner gifts are ignored or lacking the rest are empty icons that can symbolize ultimately not abundance, but lack. You are fortunate to be both rich and generous with gifts that have real value.

XIII

I'm Kissing This Cat

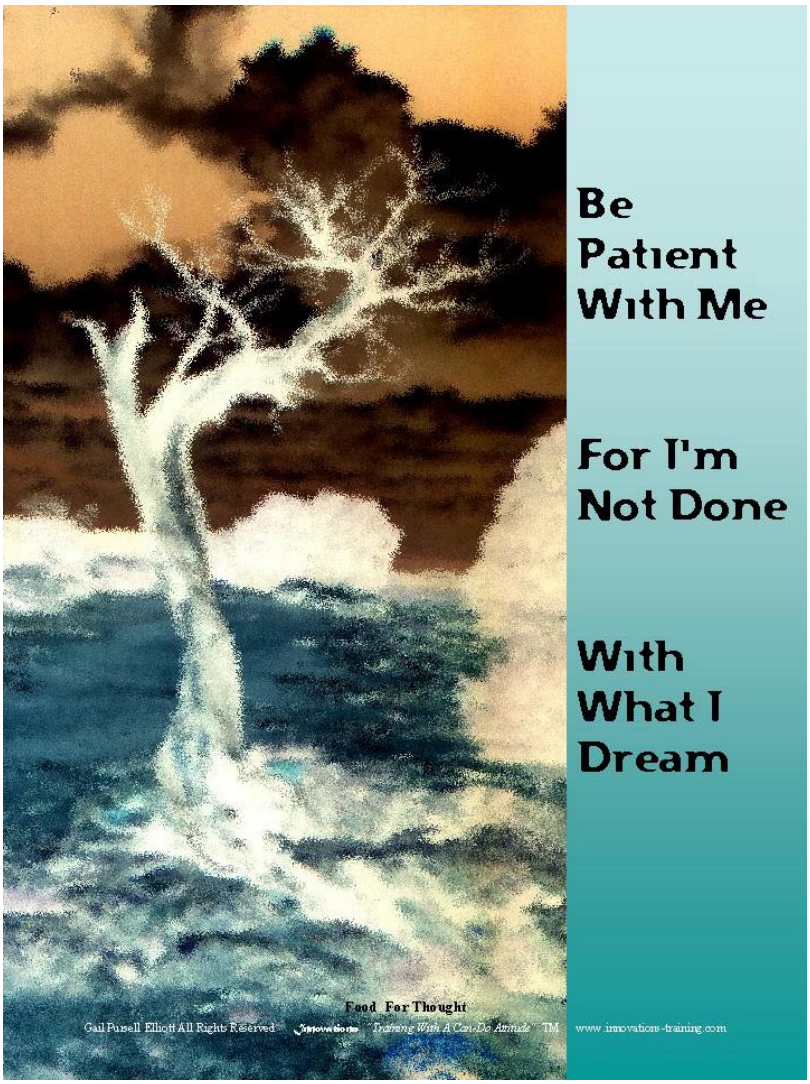
Some of the kindest and most well meaning of us can sometimes be a real pain. Generally this happens when we make observations and offer caring advice and insights that aren't requested. We think we're being supportive when we're doing this.

It's interesting that many of us offer unsolicited advice readily. Yet when asked for specific advice, we may become cautious and preface our response with some sort of disclaimer. The person may actually take our 'wind' and fill their sails with it and at that point we feel responsible.

Often this happens when we watch friends or others in our lives doing things that, based upon our own experience, we see as 'mistakes.' It may happen when someone shares dreams and desires or confides concerns. We want to 'help'. We want to 'fix' things. When we do this, we're taking someone else's experience personally.

Sometimes when we believe that we're being kind and caring, we're not treating the other person with dignity and respect. We can't understand the whole situation because we can't crawl into someone else's brain and think what they think, feel what they feel, or know what they know. Unless the other person asks for help or ideas, what they want is simply validation: external confirmation that their dream or concern is part of their reality.

A family member of mine once put it humorously when she said to a well-meaning friend, "Listen to me! I'm kissing this cat, all you have is the tail!"



XIV

But First

Most of us have had those days when we feel exhausted by the end of the day and know we've had our hands on lots of projects but don't see much in terms of results. Those are the days when we've played a game a friend once referred to as "But First." This is a game in which we allow ourselves to be distracted from our current task by others we happen to notice. We stop what we're doing and begin working on what distracted us. While working on that we become distracted by something else.

For example, we're taking an item at home from one room to another. On the way we notice that there is an item on the floor that should be picked up and put away. We put down the first item and pick up the item on the floor. We tell ourselves that we'll get that item to the other room But First we'll put this item away. While going to put it away, we notice something else. This is what I call "spontaneity at it's worst."

There is another way to play But First, a way to use it to stay focused rather than letting it distract us. Years ago a friend of mine marveled that I could walk right past something that needed to be picked up and keep on going. I told him that it was because my brain was already in the next room completing the task at hand. It was a question of priority.

Of course, we can pick up another item and take it with us if we don't allow it to distract us. Sometimes we have no choice. But First we finish the task that we began, or at least a component of it, however small, to maintain our focus. The momentum to complete major tasks is maintained by the accomplishment of smaller steps. The wonder of small achievements keeps us motivated and energized.

A lot of us describe ourselves as 'multi-taskers.' It's almost a requirement to survival in our busy world. People who are good at this aren't really doing more than one thing at a time and they are smart enough to know that. Even a juggler only holds one item in one hand at a time while watching where the others are in the air. The secret is to know when to let go of one item and catch the next one before it hits the floor. Not to drop the item in hand and grab too soon at the one approaching. The timing and the rhythm keep the momentum going.

XV

Beyond Behavior

Separating people from their actions can be one of the most difficult things to do. Separating ourselves from our actions can be equally difficult, but it's something we instinctively know is possible.

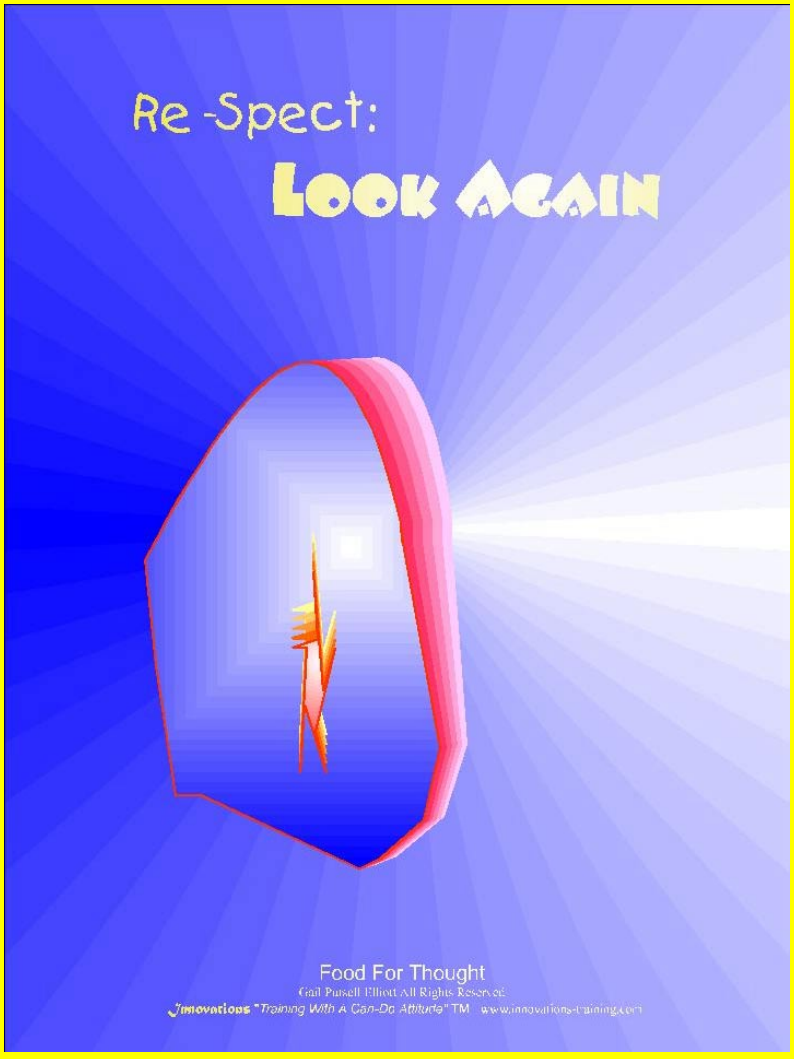
If you have ever said to yourself, "Why did I do that? That wasn't ME!" you were right. Obviously, some types of behavior are not worthy of respect, but the individual beneath the behavior is not only worthy but entitled to it. We are all 'works in progress' with an inner beauty that exists beyond behavior.

When we choose words and actions consistent with our vision of who we are beyond our behavior, regardless of what someone else says or does, we begin to close the gap between our inner reality: who we are and our outer reality: what we do. We have that power.

When we react to someone's negative behavior we are giving that behavior control over us. One popular form of personal deception is to try to 'rise above' the negative behavior. We behave in a way that we think is noble or superior or believe we are trying to use positive energy to get someone else to change. When we react in this way, it's like saying "let the games begin."

To paraphrase a quote from the last episode of the Star Wars trilogy, “Lash out in your anger and your hate and your journey to the dark side will be complete.” Most of us would rather not complete that kind of journey, but sometimes feel as if we cannot help ourselves.

The good news is that we can, by using the power of respect. When we split the word respect into syllables it becomes RE-SPECT. In other words LOOK AGAIN, beyond behavior, to acknowledge the inner beauty that exists within us all.



XVI

Life In The Biosphere

We hear the expression ‘culture’ applied to corporate and community environments so often. I’ve used the term myself. Quite frankly, it just doesn’t ‘resonate’ for me. When I think of a ‘culture’ I think of a dish in a controlled laboratory growing something that was introduced into a sterile environment. I think of bacteria. That may seem rather goofy, but that is the image that comes to mind. Even when we speak of a ‘culture’ in human terms, we speak of customs, issues, and practices that determine and control the growth and behavior of the members.

When it comes to environments, in which people live and work, try thinking of creating not a ‘culture’ but a ‘biosphere.’ By definition, the biosphere is the part of the earth’s crust that supports life.

Part of treating others with dignity and respect means allowing them to BE. Without being judged or expected to live up to someone else’s idea of what they should be. This is not to say that groups that interact with one another, whether large or small, should not have laws or rules of conduct. This is a deeper matter than that and perhaps is the real meaning of ‘diversity.’

Being treated with dignity and respect honors the unique potential that is in each of us, allows it to flourish by creating a positive atmosphere that supports life and growth. Whether in our homes, our communities, or in our workplaces, the concept of a 'biosphere' has to do with subscribing to an ethic that goes beyond 'culture.' It promotes individuality, creativity, imagination, inspiration, respect, understanding, awareness, and above all – peace.

Being treated with dignity and respect honors the unique potential that is in each of us, It promotes individuality, creativity, imagination, inspiration, respect, understanding, awareness, and above all – peace.

XVII

Seven Points To Ponder

1. "Failure is an event, not a person." – Zig Ziglar

To me this means that although it's possible to experience failure as a temporary event in life, it's not possible for any of us to be a failure.

2. "Live in the present."

It seems that many of us live more in the past and the future than in the present. When we allow what has happened or what we hope will happen to distract us from the present, we fragment ourselves and lose both concentration and focus.

3. "The harder you try the harder things get."

This may sound silly, but have you ever heard of a couple who tried for years to have a child and couldn't? Then when they'd given up and adopted, suddenly they conceived a child of their own. This is an example of what happens to all of us in many different ways. We 'try too hard' and actually block our good from coming to us.

4. Develop "Gattitude" (a 'gratitude attitude.')

This can seem hard during those times when we feel that our dreams have been shattered, but we are ALWAYS in control of what our response is to whatever comes into our experience.

5. "No masterpiece was ever created by a lazy artist." – Eleanor Thompson

This is a quote from a teacher I had years ago. She was a very good painter. But more than that, she loved her art. She couldn't keep her hands off it. She even created abstract designs on her lawn with creeping plants. Love your inner music -whatever is your gift and your passion. You can never turn your back on it.

6. "Figure out what you really want."

Not the results of what we want but the essence of what it is. Then, regardless of what direction we take, we know where we're ultimately headed.

7. "Everything you need to know already exists inside of you."

Learning and discovery is simply a process of recognition or 'waking up.'



About the Author

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And poetry

Mother of two wonderful teenagers

Owner of a spoiled old dog and a one-eyed kitty

Started writing in her teens. First published in 1970.

Started painting in her twenties.

Relies on Miracles.

"Thank you for allowing me to share my thoughts and vision with you.

If this book has given you 'food for thought,' I'd love to hear from you.

Have a Great Day!" - Gail

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